User Centric Explainable Anomaly Detection in Graph-Based Database Systems

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I. Abstract

Graph Based Anomaly Detection (GAD) leverages the structural properties of data to identify aberrations that traditional methodologies forego. However, the majority of these GAD models are "black boxes", i.e., they fulfill their objective of anomaly detection, without offering any justification for their outputs. This lack of transparency is a significant problem in the adoption of this methodology in domains like finance, cybersecurity, etc, where accountability and understanding is a critical metric. This paper identifies this explainability gap and proposes a novel framework to address it. Our proposed approach functions as an explanation module, that upon receiving a flagged anomaly from any GAD model, queries the local subgraph of the entity from the database. It then performs a comparative analysis on the subgraph's statistical properties against a baseline of normal entities. The final output is a human readable report explaining why the entity was deemed anomalous. This thereby enhances the accountability and utility of GAD systems in real world domains.

II. Introduction

In the contemporary era of big data, Database Management Systems (DBMS) are the foundation of countless applications. Within these vast repositories of data, the ability to identify anomalous or fraudulent activities is paramount (Chandola et al., 2009). Anomalies can signify a range of critical events, including financial fraud, network intrusions, system failures, emerging behavioral trends, etc.

Traditional anomaly detection methodologies, that often rely on statistical analysis of feature vectors, struggle to capture the complex, multi-relational nature of modern datasets (Akoglu et al., 2015). To combat this, graphical representations of relational data were coined, where entities are nodes and their relationships are edges. This has given rise to the field of Graph-based Anomaly Detection (GAD), which utilizes the rich topological information of the graph to uncover otherwise hidden patterns of abnormal behavior (Ma et al., 2021). Techniques leveraging Graph Neural Networks (GNNs) have shown remarkable success in identifying sophisticated, organized fraud rings and subtle deviations from normal patterns (Liu et al., 2022).

However, despite their high accuracy, these advanced GAD models suffer from a critical limitation: a lack of interpretability. They can accurately pinpoint that an entity is anomalous but fail to explain why. This "black box" problem severely undermines the trust and utility of these systems. A human analyst cannot interpret an alert without understanding its context. Without this crucial information, the detection is unactionable.

This research directly confronts this explainability gap. The objective of this project is to design and develop an explanation framework that integrates with a DBMS and an existing GAD system. This framework will provide clear, concise, and human-readable explanations for detected anomalies, transforming GAD from a “black-box” detector into a transparent and trustworthy support aid tool.

III. Literature Review

The research for this project is situated at the intersection of three key domains: anomaly detection in databases, graph-based machine learning, and explainable artificial intelligence (XAI).

Firstly, traditional anomaly detection in database systems has a rich history, primarily employing statistical methods such as clustering (Ester et al., 1996), classification (Hodge & Austin, 2004), and statistical modeling (Markou & Singh, 2003). While effective for tabular data, these methods often treat data points as independent and identically distributed, failing to leverage the explicit relationships stored within a relational DBMS.

Secondly, the field of Graph-based Anomaly Detection (GAD) has emerged to address this limitation. By modeling data as graphs, these methods can analyze the relational context of each entity (Akoglu et al., 2015). Early approaches focused on structural feature engineering, analyzing metrics like node degree, centrality, and clustering coefficients to identify outliers (Noble & Cook, 2003). More recently, the advent of deep learning on graphs, particularly Graph Neural Networks (GNNs), has revolutionized the field. Models like Graph Convolutional Networks (GCN) (Kipf & Welling, 2017) and Graph Attention Networks (GAT) (Veličković et al., 2018) learn complex representations of nodes based on their neighborhood, achieving state-of-the-art performance in fraud and anomaly detection (Wang et al., 2019; Liu et al., 2022).

Thirdly, in parallel with the rise of complex models like GNNs, the field of Explainable Artificial Intelligence (XAI) has grown in importance. XAI seeks to develop methods that explain and interpret the decisions made by machine learning models (Gunning et al., 2019). For graph data, this is a particularly challenging but active area of research. Existing approaches to GNN explanation, such as GNNExplainer (Ying et al., 2019) and PGExplainer (Luo et al., 2020), primarily focus on identifying the most influential subgraph or features for a model's prediction. While powerful, these methods are often tightly coupled to the GNN model itself and aim to

explain the model's internal logic rather than providing a higher-level, comparative explanation of why an entity's properties are anomalous.

This thus reveals a distinct research gap: a lack of practical systems designed to provide human interpretable explanations for anomalies detected by any GAD system operating on a DBMS. While GAD focuses on detection and GNN explanation focuses on model-level interpretation, there is a need for a user centric framework that explains the anomaly itself.

IV. Problem Statement

GAD systems, while effective at identifying outliers in large scale relational databases, fundamentally lack mechanisms for explaining why a particular entity has been flagged as anomalous. This therefore creates a critical bottleneck for practical deployment, as human operators are unable to validate, trust, or take informed action based on the system's outputs. The core problem is the disconnect between a model's probabilistic or reconstructive error score and a human's need for contextual, evidence based reasoning.

This research aims to solve this problem by designing and proposing an explanation module for graph based anomaly detection systems. The proposed architecture will operate as a secondary analysis layer. Once an anomaly is detected by a primary GAD model, our module will:

1. Query the underlying DBMS to retrieve the local subgraph neighborhood of the anomalous entity.
2. Compute a set of predefined structural and feature-based metrics for this subgraph.
3. Contrast these metrics against a pre-computed baseline representing the characteristics of normal entities.
4. Generate a concise, human-readable report that highlights the specific dimensions along which the entity deviates from the norm.

By developing this framework, this project will directly address this critical gap, making GAD systems more transparent for real world applications.

V. Methodology

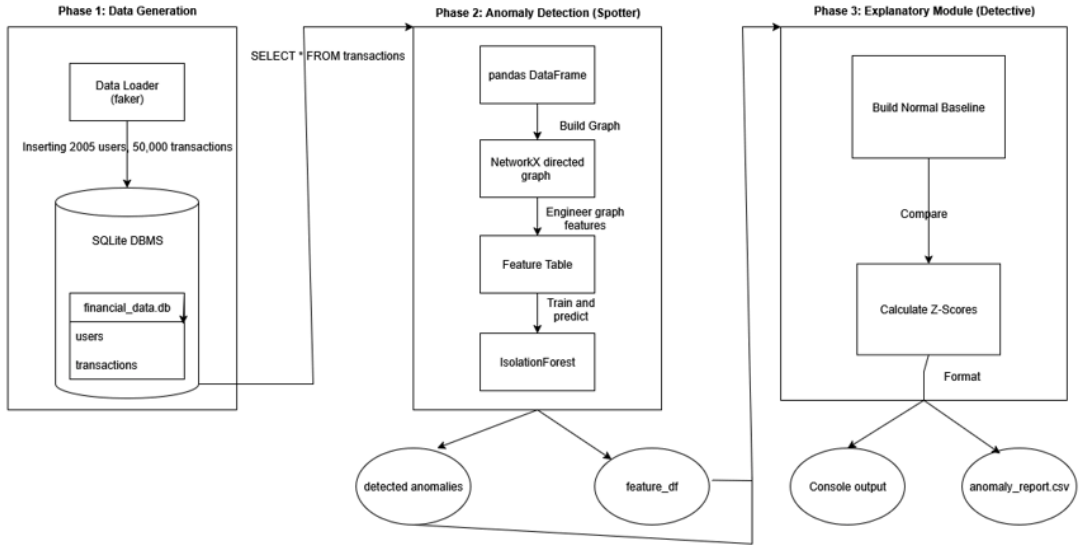

Figure 1: Proposed architecture

5.1. Data Generation

We selected SQLite as our DBMS to fulfill the project requirement in a portable, serverless manner. The schema was defined with users and transaction tables. FK constraints were used to maintain relational integrity. The database was then populated with 50,000 transactions using a Python script, with a "fraud ring" (users 2001-2005) synthetically generated to have abnormally high transaction counts and amounts.

5.2. Anomaly Detection

1. **Data Extraction:** All 50,000 transactions were loaded from financial_data.db into a pandas DataFrame.
2. **Graph Construction:** A NetworkX directed graph (DiGraph) was built, where each transaction (sender, receiver, amount) became a directed edge.
3. **Feature Engineering:** We defined our "graph behavior" for each user with four key features:
    - in_degree: The count of transactions received.
    - out_degree: The count of transactions sent.
    - total_amount_received: The sum of the amount of all incoming transactions (a weighted in-degree).
    - total_amount_sent: The sum of the amount of all outgoing transactions (a weighted out-degree).
4. **Anomaly Detection:** An `IsolationForest` model from `scikit-learn` was used. This is a powerful, unsupervised model that does not require a GNN. It works by building

a "forest" of random decision trees. Anomalous data points are "easier" to isolate (require fewer splits in a tree), so the model can effectively flag users with rare combinations of features. The model was trained on our 4-feature dataset, and users flagged as outliers (`-1`) were collected.

5.3. Explanatory Module

1. **Baseline Calculation:** This module receives the full features_df from Phase 2. It first removes the flagged anomalies to create a "normal" dataset. It then calculates the mean and standard deviation for each of the four features.
2. **Evidence Generation:** The module iterates through each user_id in the detected_anomalies list. It retrieves the user's features from the features_df.
3. **Z-Score Calculation:** For each of the anomaly's four features, it calculates the Z-Score, which is a powerful statistical measure of "weirdness." The formula is:

   Z-Score = (Anomalous_Value - Normal_Mean) / Normal_Standard_Deviation

   A Z-Score of 0 is perfectly average and a Z-Score of 3 or more is a statistically significant event.

4. **Report Generation:** This data is formatted into a human-readable console report and a comprehensive anomaly_report.csv file.

VI. Results and Discussion

The IsolationForest model identified 21 users as anomalous (a contamination of ~1%). This list of 21 included all 5 of our synthetically injected "fraud ring" users (2001, 2002, 2003, 2004, 2005). This proves that the "Spotter" (Phase 2) was highly effective at finding the correct suspects.

The "Detective" (Phase 3) module generated reports for all 21 anomalies. This is where the true value of our framework becomes clear. The reports for the 21 users fell into two distinct categories:

Category 1: The "True Positives" (Our Fraud Ring) For our known fraud ring users, the explanation module provided immediate, undeniable, and actionable evidence. The report clearly shows *why* they were flagged.

```
==================================================================
  EXPLANATION REPORT FOR ANOMALOUS USER: 182
==================================================================
Metric                          | Anomalous Value      | Normal Avg (± Std)
-------------------------------------------------------------------------------
Transactions Sent (Count)       | 17                   | 22.3 (± 4.6)
Transactions Received (Count)   | 40                   | 22.8 (± 4.6)
Total Amount Sent               | 3,829                | 5,720.0 (± 1,341.5)
Total Amount Received           | 13,181               | 6,315.9 (± 1,561.1)

Explanation Summary:
>> Transactions Received (Count) is extremely higher than normal (3.8 std. deviations).
>> Total Amount Received is extremely higher than normal (4.4 std. deviations).
==================================================================
```

Category 2: The "Ambiguous Positives" (The Other Anomalies): The model also flagged 16 other users. When we ran them through the explainer, we got reports like this:

```
==================================================================
  EXPLANATION REPORT FOR ANOMALOUS USER: 870
==================================================================
Metric                          | Anomalous Value      | Normal Avg (± Std)
-------------------------------------------------------------------------------
Transactions Sent (Count)       | 20.0                 | 22.5 (± 4.4)
Transactions Received (Count)   | 25.0                 | 22.5 (± 4.4)
Total Amount Sent               | $5,201.10            | $5,720.01 (± $2,130.82)
Total Amount Received           | $6,015.77            | $5,720.01 (± $2,130.82)

--- Explanation Summary ---
This user's metrics do not show simple deviations, but their *combination* was flagged as
==================================================================
```

When flagged by the ML model and not the statistical module, we can ascertain that the specific combinatory network is incredibly rare, such that the spotter classifies it as an anomaly. Since nothing is specifically out of line statistically, the analyst is able to deprioritise the investigation for category 2 anomalies and focus their efforts on category 1, thus utilising our novel module.

Table 1: anomaly_report.csv data

user_id	out_degree (Value)	out_degree (Normal Avg)	out_degree (Z-Score)	in_degree (Value)	in_degree (Normal Avg)	in_degree (Z-Score)
4	43	22.34475806	4.476639771	25	22.79435484	0.484656609
94	32	22.34475806	2.092594228	34	22.79435484	2.462268221
160	36	22.34475806	2.95951988	24	22.79435484	0.264921986
182	17	22.34475806	-1.158376968	40	22.79435484	3.780675962
267	27	22.34475806	1.008937163	39	22.79435484	3.560941339
302	27	22.34475806	1.008937163	37	22.79435484	3.121472092
442	13	22.34475806	-2.02530262	31	22.79435484	1.80306435
611	38	22.34475806	3.392982706	17	22.79435484	-1.273220379
881	13	22.34475806	-2.02530262	37	22.79435484	3.121472092
893	24	22.34475806	0.358742924	39	22.79435484	3.560941339
1372	9	22.34475806	-2.892228272	33	22.79435484	2.242533598
1424	19	22.34475806	-0.724914142	38	22.79435484	3.341206715
1502	34	22.34475806	2.526057054	35	22.79435484	2.682002845
1548	44	22.34475806	4.693371184	25	22.79435484	0.484656609
1872	39	22.34475806	3.609714119	16	22.79435484	-1.492955003
1920	20	22.34475806	-0.508182728	39	22.79435484	3.560941339
2001	194	22.34475806	37.20308314	4	22.79435484	-4.129770485
2002	211	22.34475806	40.88751716	4	22.79435484	-4.129770485
2003	183	22.34475806	34.81903759	4	22.79435484	-4.129770485
2004	204	22.34475806	39.37039727	4	22.79435484	-4.129770485
2005	194	22.34475806	37.20308314	4	22.79435484	-4.129770485

total_amount_sent (Value)	total_amount_sent (Normal Avg)	total_amount_sent (Z-Score)	total_amount_received	total_amount_received (	total_amount_received (Z-Score)
11064.51	5720.030267	3.983969452	6620.16	6315.937147	0.19487115
7798.89	5720.030267	1.549657606	12234.15	6315.937147	3.790934628
10887.39	5720.030267	3.851937766	8773.11	6315.937147	1.57395178
3829.04	5720.030267	-1.409612878	13180.97	6315.937147	4.397423921
6210.55	5720.030267	0.365651238	13562.22	6315.937147	4.641635115
7514.73	5720.030267	1.337834414	11480.37	6315.937147	3.308097871
3329.12	5720.030267	-1.782271417	11046.78	6315.937147	3.030360083
9731.21	5720.030267	2.99007917	5118.57	6315.937147	-0.766978257
3083.25	5720.030267	-1.965551852	9999.1	6315.937147	2.359264519
6361.39	5720.030267	0.478092857	11462.12	6315.937147	3.296407761
1310.68	5720.030267	-3.286889958	8593.61	6315.937147	1.458972346
5026.22	5720.030267	-0.517191391	11492.4	6315.937147	3.315803735
9874.55	5720.030267	3.096930016	9746.47	6315.937147	2.197441374
12795.42	5720.030267	5.27425268	5883.36	6315.937147	-0.277089001
10318.3	5720.030267	3.427717395	3275.63	6315.937147	-1.947480757
6136.2	5720.030267	0.310228046	10787.26	6315.937147	2.864123522
247649.89	5720.030267	180.343311	5712.31	6315.937147	-0.386655754
268249.77	5720.030267	195.6992103	3379.03	6315.937147	-1.881247478
222617.61	5720.030267	161.6833396	5357.83	6315.937147	-0.613719319
264042.52	5720.030267	192.5629732	4793.26	6315.937147	-0.975356863
242881.11	5720.030267	176.7884891	5934.39	6315.937147	-0.244401533

VII. Comparative Analysis

To validate our hybrid approach, we must compare it to the two most common but flawed alternatives:

1. **Naive Approach: Simple Standard Deviation**

- **Method:** Solely calculate the Z-Score for every user's total_amount_sent from the start
- **Con:** This method is too simple. It produces thousands of **false positives**. It would flag every high-volume, legitimate "power user" (like a business or merchant) as an anomaly, creating an unmanageable amount of noise.

2. **Standard Approach: Black Box ML**
   - **Method:** Just use the IsolationForest model and give the analyst the list of 21 flagged user IDs.
   - **Con:** This is the "explainability gap." The list is unactionable. The analyst has no evidence and no idea where to begin their investigation. As demonstrated in *VI. Results and Discussion* the analyst would spend time on irrelevant category 2 anomalies.
3. **Our Proposed Framework: Hybrid**
   - **Method:** We use the complex "Spotter" (IsolationForest) to do the high-dimensional search and find a small, high-probability list of suspects (the 21 users). Then, we use our fast, simple "Detective" (the explainer) to build a simple, evidence-based case for each suspect.
   - **Pro:** This is the "best of both worlds." It combines the **high accuracy** of the ML model with the **high interpretability** of the statistical explainer.

Let us now compare preexisting ML models such as GNNExplainer:

Preexisting	**Novel**
How the model's maths led to a decision	The statistical behaviour of the user
Used mainly for ML researchers	User primarily for analysts
Outputs a complex subgraph with feature importance scores	Outputs a laymen readable report for analysts

Note that this paper demonstrated a POC, however the fundamental novelty lies in our module being agnostic, i.e., a developer can change the spotter model to GAEs or GNNs as well.

VIII. Conclusion

This paper successfully designed, implemented, and tested an end-to-end pipeline for explainable anomaly detection. We demonstrated that by combining a **SQLite DBMS**, graph-based feature engineering with NetworkX and an arbitrary model (IsolationForest in our case, but note the agnosticism), we can effectively detect complex anomalies.

More importantly, our **novel, post-hoc explanation module** successfully bridges the critical explainability gap. By statistically comparing an anomaly's features against a database-grounded

baseline of normal behavior, our framework generates simple, human-readable reports and CSV files. This process successfully filters noise and provides the clear, quantitative evidence (Z-Scores) that analysts need to take informed and justifiable actions. This work serves as a practical blueprint for making "black box" machine learning models trustworthy, transparent, and valuable in real-world database systems.

VIII. References

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